

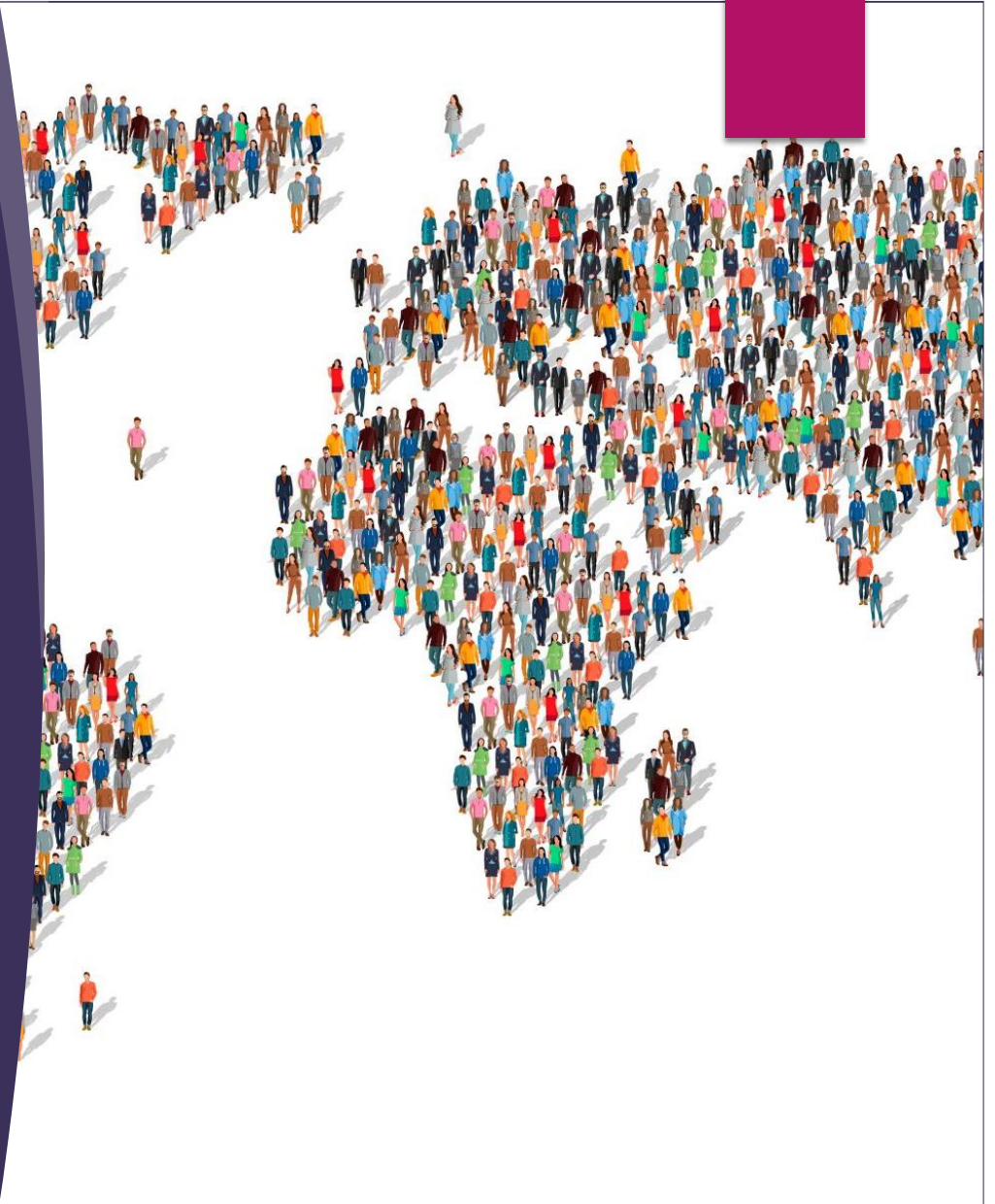
Engaging Key Population

BEST PRACTICES FOR INCLUSIVE AND EFFECTIVE
ENGAGEMENT

SEAN LORD

SUPPORT SERVICES OFFICER

EQUALITY FOR ALL FOUNDATION



Understanding Key Population in Jamaica

- ▶ **Key Population** refers to groups that are disproportionately affected by HIV, Stigma, Discrimination and other social and structural barriers to healthcare and human rights.
- ▶ Key population in Jamaica typically include:
 - **Men who have sex with men** – face high levels of stigma, discrimination and legal barriers due to Jamaica's law criminalizing same-sex intimacy.
 - **Sex Workers** – Experience marginalization, legal challenges and increased vulnerability to violence and health risks.
 - **Transgender Individuals** – Face significant discrimination, social exclusion, and barriers to gender-affirming healthcare.
 - **People living with HIV** – Encounter stigma and discrimination that affect their access to healthcare, employment and social support.

Why is recognizing Key Population important?

- ▶ The recognition of key population is essential for targeted interventions, advocacy and policy change.
- ▶ This is aimed at reducing health disparities, protect human rights and promote inclusive developments.

The Importance of Inclusive Engagement

- ▶ **Addressing Social and Economic Inequalities** – Due to systematic discrimination, inclusive engagement ensures that these groups have access to resources, opportunities and protection.
- ▶ **Strengthening Public Health Responses** – Engaging KP in policy development, service provision and advocacy helps to tailor intervention to their specific needs.
- ▶ **Enhancing Human Rights and Social Justice** – Inclusive engagement affirms the dignity and rights of all individual. It fosters legal and policy reform that protect marginalized groups from discrimination, violence and social exclusion.
- ▶ **Strengthening Community Resilience and Participation** – When KP are engaged in governance, community programs and advocacy, they become stakeholders in nation-building.

Key Principles for Engagement

To effectively engage KP, stakeholders **MUST** adopt an approach rooted in human rights, equity and meaningful participation.

- ▶ **Human Rights Approach** – all engagement must be respectful and promote fundamental rights and dignity.
- ▶ **Meaningful Participation and Representation** – KP must be actively involved in decision-making processes that affects their lives. This involves representation in policy development, program design and service delivery.
- ▶ **Non-Discrimination and Equity** – Engagement efforts should be inclusive and equitable, ensuring that KP receives fair access to opportunities, services and protection without bias, based on gender identity, sexual identity, sexual orientation or health status.
- ▶ **Confidentiality and Safety** – Given the risk of stigma, discrimination and violence, all interactions must uphold strict confidentiality and prioritize their physical, emotional and psychological safety.

Key Strategies for Engaging Safe Spaces and Community Building

▶ Engaging Safe Physical and Virtual Spaces.

- Develop secure, accessible and affirming spaces where KP can access resources, counseling, peer support and legal support.
- Use social media, WhatsApp support networks and online platforms to provide access to information especially in rural and high-risk areas.

▶ Capacity Building and Community-Led Programming.

- Train and empower educators and mentors to provide guidance, mental health support and HIV/STI prevention strategies.
- Provide free or low-cost healthcare services.

▶ Crisis Response Support

- Establish rapid response network for individuals facing violence, eviction, and discrimination.

Effective Communication Strategies

▶ **Culturally Relevant and Inclusive Messaging.**

- Use language that is affirming, respectful and free from stigma.
- Ensure messaging reflecting the lived identities of key populations
- Incorporate pronouns where applicable.

▶ **Trusted Community Messengers.**

- Partner with activists and advocates who have credibility within KP.
- Train peer educators to serve as liaisons and advocates.

▶ **Strategic Partnerships and Collaboration.**

- Work with NGOs, healthcare providers and government agencies.
- Engage the media to ensure fair coverage of KP issues.

Addressing Barriers to Engagement

► **Stigma and Discrimination – Discourages KP from seeking services or engaging in community programs.**

- Implement anti-discrimination policies in organizations and service delivery
- Provide sensitivity training for healthcare providers, law enforcement and service professionals.
- Use rights-based messaging to promote dignity and respect for all individuals.

► **Fear of violence and safety concerns – Threats of physical violence, harassment and abuse create hostile environments for engagement.**

- Establish safe spaces for KP to access support services.
- Develop anonymous and discreet communication channels (EFAF Helpline)

► **Limited Access to information and Services** – Many KP do not have access to relevant and accurate information.

- Develop easy to understand resources

► **Legal and Policy Restrictions** – Criminalizing of same-sex intimacy, sex work and drug use discourages engagement.

- Advocate for policy change to protect KP rights.
- Conduct sensitization campaigns to shift public and political perspectives.
- Work with legal support organizations to offer assistance and representation.

Partnering with Key Population focused Organizations

Requires strategic partnerships with organizations that specialize in serving KP.

1. Identify and Map KP-Focused Organizations.

(Equality For all Foundation, Sex Workers Association of Jamaica, Transwave) and assess their strengths, areas of focus, and existing services to ensure they align with your goals.

2. Capacity Building and Resource Sharing

Provide training, funding or logistic support to strengthen the capacity of KP focused organizations.

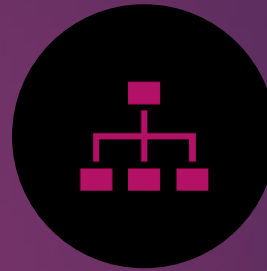
3. Strengthen Referral and Support Systems

Establish clear referral pathways between your organization and KP-focused organizations to ensure seamless access to services.

Practical Steps for Engagement



1. Training & Sensitization - Educate service providers



2. Policy Development - Integrate inclusivity into policies.



3. Community Outreach - Conduct forums and awareness sessions.



4. Helpline & Support Services - Offer confidential resources.

Advocacy & Policy Reform

Engaging KP can take form of supporting Decriminalization & Anti-Discrimination Laws, Workplace & Healthcare Inclusivity Support legal reforms and Public Awareness Campaigns

- ▶ Section 76, 77 and 79 of the Offences Against the Person Act criminalizes same-sex intimacy which perpetuates stigma, discrimination and violence against LGBTQI+ individuals.
- ▶ The Sexual Offences Act and the Town and Communities Act criminalizes sex work which increases vulnerability to violence, police abuse and lack of access to health services.
- ▶ The lack of comprehensive Anti-Discrimination Protection increase discrimination based on sexual orientation, gender identity or HIV status in key areas of employment, healthcare, housing and education.

How can we provide support by way of Advocacy and Policy Reform?

► Repeal of Anti-LGBTQI+ Laws

- Advocacy for the repeal of Section 76, 77 and 79 of the Offences Against the Person Act to be aligned with international human rights standards (freedom to privacy)

► Decriminalization of Sex Work

- Shift from criminalization to rights-based regulatory approach that prioritize health, safety and labour protections.

► Public education and Sensitization

- Engage media, faith-based groups and policymakers to shift public opinion.

Conclusion & Call to Action

Every individual has a role in fostering inclusivity.

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Commit to respectful language and safe engagement strategies.

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Support and amplify KP voices in Jamaica.